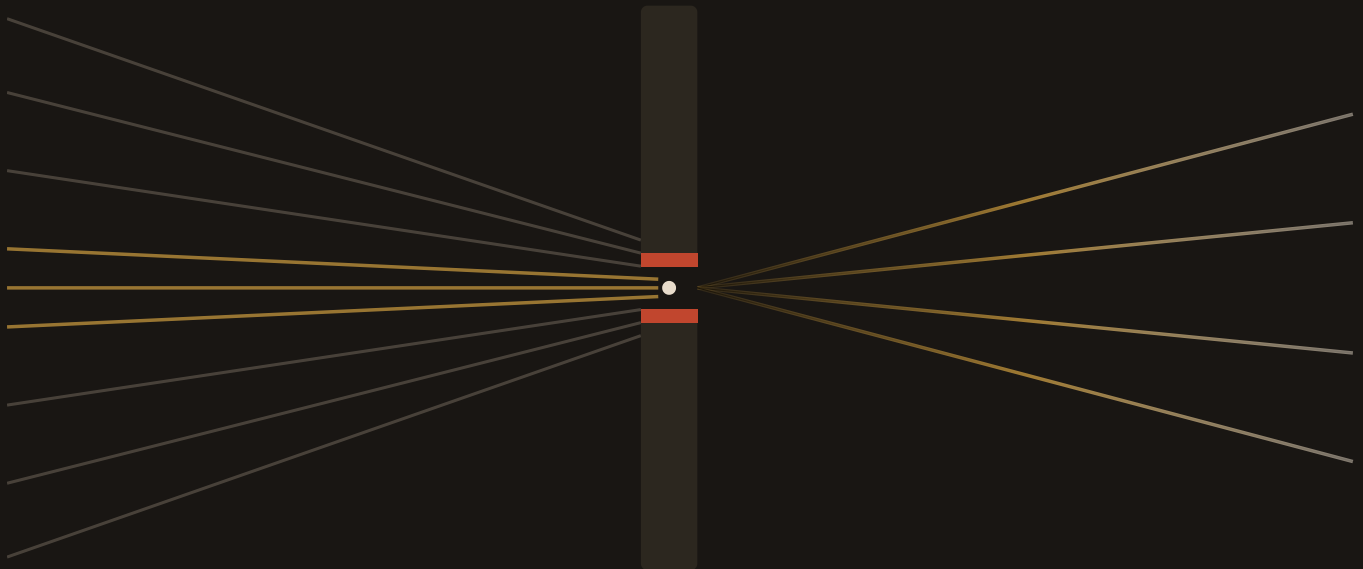


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.



EVERYTHING PASSES THROUGH THE NARROWEST POINT — OR IT DOESN'T PASS

THE WORLD

Yemen's Houthis blockade Saudi Arabia and a third American dies as the Gulf war spreads to six states in seventy-two hours

TECHNOLOGY

A gas nobody outside a fab had heard of just became a chokepoint — a quarter of the world's supply switched off for good

SINGAPORE

A decades-long front-bench career ends within a day of a single email reaching the Prime Minister's Office

THIS ISSUE

Contents

p3–4 The World — a widening Gulf war, a Houthis blockade of Saudi Arabia, and a strike commander handed Kyiv's war ministry

p5 Singapore — a minister resigns within a day; the opposition loses its elder statesman the same week

p6 Property — Jurong's "second CBD" anchor site returns, smaller and state-subsidised

p7–8 Technology — the chokepoint moves from the chip to a single gas; the memory shortage gets a deadline

p9 The Kit — the night before Unpacked, the watch leaks do the talking

p10 The Connected Home — the Matter server catches up to the spec it just chased

p11 The Good Life — a flagship season for high-end audio, while two watch results stay unresolved

p12 Screen & Sound — Apple TV+ takes Hall H solo, without a franchise behind it

p13–14 The Family Desk — Roblox's settlement math grows to five states; a sceptic's read on Google's "unacceptable risk"

p15 The Macro Desk — an oil shock reaches the drinking water, and a hawkish chair repriced July

p16 Curiosities — a cockroach in a diving suit, a worm with metal teeth, a salamander thirty years late

p17 Love & Life — an algorithm wants to pick who you fall for, and the internet noticed

p18 Fitness — your handshake, your brain, and the difference between a correlation and a cure

p19–20 The Diary — the October squeeze, and four fresh names for The Table

p21–23 The Long Read — "The Narrowest Point"

FROM THE DESK

"In every chain of reasoning, the evidence of the last conclusion can be no greater than that of the weakest link of the chain, whatever may be the strength of the rest."

— Thomas Reid, *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man* (1786), Essay VII¹

It fits an issue that kept turning on its narrowest parts. A regional war concentrated onto two thin straits and a single desalination plant. A quarter of the world's supply of one obscure chipmaking gas switched off — not by force, but by denying two factories a raw material. A minister's decades-long career ended over one email. In each, what broke was not the biggest part of the system but its weakest link. This issue's Long Read ([p21](#)) follows that idea through Augustus guarding Egypt's grain, Germany engineering past a British blockade, and Britain's reach unravelling at Suez.

BRENT CRUDE

~\$89.2 ▲

GOLD (XAU)

\$4,001 ▼

VWRA

\$186.98 ▼

USD/SGD

1.2913

US 10-YEAR

~4.60% ▲

THE WEEK AT A GLANCE

Widened: the Gulf war reached a Houthis blockade of Saudi Arabia and a Kuwaiti desalination plant, killing a third American in three days.

Switched off: a quarter of the world's high-purity tungsten-hexafluoride capacity, gone for good, taking out a chokepoint nobody thought to stockpile.

Resigned: Faishal Ibrahim, minister and MP, within a day of one email — the portfolios reassigned the same afternoon ([p5](#)).

Repriced: the odds of a July Fed hike, from under 10% to the high-30s–40s, on a hawkish week from Chair Warsh ([p15](#)).

STANDING NOTE

This issue runs as a straight news book, not a themed spine — no single motif forced across all twelve desks. Only the Long Read ([p21](#)) argues one connected idea, deliberately: the habit of bending every desk toward a unifying theme starts to show its own machinery if run too often, and a few issues in every stretch are better served by simply reporting the week well.

SOURCES ¹ Thomas Reid, *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man*, Essay VII (1786). Market strip: Trading Economics, StockAnalysis.com, Yahoo Finance SG — levels as of 19–20 Jul 2026, subject to change by press time.

THE WORLD · THE GULF WAR, DAY 28

Houthis Blockade Saudi Arabia as the Gulf War Widens Further

A third American service member is dead and Iranian fire has now reached six Gulf states in 72 hours, as Yemen's Houthis open a new front against Riyadh in the Red Sea.

Two days after Tehran declared its Islamabad ceasefire framework dead, the war it was meant to end has widened rather than narrowed. Yemen's Houthi movement announced Monday that it is imposing a maritime "blockade" on Saudi Arabia through the Bab el-Mandeb strait — the corridor carrying roughly a tenth of world trade — retaliating, it said, for a Saudi-enforced blockade of Yemen and a strike on Sanaa's airport.¹ The declaration lands as the United States confirmed a third American service member killed in the war's spillover in three days, taking the U.S. combat toll to 17.²

The geography keeps stretching. Iranian missiles and drones have now struck or been intercepted over Bahrain, Qatar, Oman and the UAE, joining Jordan, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia itself, as the U.S. flew its ninth consecutive night of strikes into Monday.³ Kuwait's state oil company reported "significant material damage and some injuries" after repeated hits on an offshore platform and a desalination plant near Shuwaikh — the second Gulf energy facility, after last week's terminal strike, pulled directly into the fighting.⁴

17

US SERVICE MEMBERS NOW CONFIRMED KILLED IN THE WAR'S SPILLOVER ACROSS JORDAN AND IRAQ — A THIRD FATALITY IN THREE DAYS, PER US CENTRAL COMMAND.

Markets are pricing the widening in real time. Brent closed Monday near \$89 after President Trump warned Iran "will pay" for the American deaths — oil is up roughly a fifth this month, with traders watching whether slower Hormuz traffic plus the new Bab el-Mandeb threat push it past \$100.⁵ The backdrop is a policy Washington half-reversed: Trump's proposed 20% "Guardian of the Strait" toll on Hormuz cargo lasted barely a day before being swapped for Gulf-state investment pledges, though the naval blockade on Iranian-flagged shipping remains.⁶ See [p15](#).

GULF WIDENS

HORMUZ

OIL SHOCK

DOHA

AL JAZEERA FRAMING

Rolling coverage frames the Houthi blockade as the predictable extension of a war Washington restarted, not Tehran's alone: it leads on the US having flown a ninth night of strikes before any new front opened, and quotes Gulf officials warning the region — not the belligerents — is absorbing the costs, from Kuwait's punctured energy output to Saudi refineries under repeated fire since February. The throughline: a ceasefire collapsing was foreseeable the moment Washington called the MoU "over" at the NATO summit.

TEHRAN

PRESS TV / IRNA FRAMING

Iranian state media casts every Iranian action since 18 July as defensive. Press TV has run the Foreign Ministry's statement that strikes on US-linked bases exercise the "inherent right to self-defence" under UN Charter Article 51, arguing Washington nullified the Islamabad MoU first by keeping its naval blockade in place. Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf has said there is "no reason to remain committed" to a framework Washington isn't honouring — the line: Iran didn't walk away, it was pushed.

BEIJING

CHINESE STATE MEDIA FRAMING

Chinese commentary is using the moment to argue American power is overextended, not triumphant. A Global Times op-ed by Fudan University's Sun Degang likened the US position in the Strait of Hormuz to Britain's during the 1956 Suez crisis — a declining power discovering its writ no longer runs — citing the absence of NATO allies in the campaign. Beijing's Foreign Ministry calls its own posture "objective, just and balanced," a neutrality some Western analysts read as China quietly banking the war's side effects without paying its costs.

SOURCES 1 Al Jazeera, "Yemen's Houthis declare naval blockade of Saudi Arabia," 20 Jul 2026. 2 NBC News / NPR, CENTCOM reporting, 18–20 Jul 2026. 3 Al Jazeera, "Gulf states come under Iranian fire as US strikes intensify," 18 Jul 2026; NPR, 20 Jul 2026. 4 Maritime Executive, "Kuwait Reports Attack on Offshore Oil Platform," 19 Jul 2026. 5 CNBC, "Oil prices rise after Trump says Iran will pay," 20 Jul 2026. 6 CNBC / Breitbart, 13–14 Jul 2026.

KYIV HANDS ITS WAR MINISTRY TO A STRIKE COMMANDER

Ukraine's defence ministry now has a war-fighter in the acting chair. Yevhen Khmara — until last week acting head of the SBU security service, and before that commander of its Alpha special-operations unit and long-range strike programme — took over as acting defence minister on 20 July, President Zelensky citing his "unprecedented experience in technology-driven strike operations" as exactly what wartime procurement and battlefield coordination need.¹ Formal Rada confirmation, delayed by the chamber's summer recess, is now expected in mid-August rather than this week, First Deputy Speaker Oleksandr Kornienko says² — leaving Khmara running the ministry through Russia's heaviest barrage of the summer: 41 ballistic and cruise missiles, including ten Zircon hypersonics, plus 125 attack drones against Kyiv overnight on 19 July, killing at least one person and wounding sixteen.³

CONGO'S EBOLA CROSSES 900 DEATHS AS WHO CALLS IT "A FIRE"

The Bundibugyo-strain outbreak declared in eastern Congo on 15 May is now, by the WHO's own description, the fastest-spreading Ebola epidemic on record. Monday's health-ministry count put deaths at 930 and confirmed cases at 2,344 — up from 828 dead a week earlier — with 37 new deaths logged in a single 24-hour span over the weekend and most new infections now tracing to unknown chains of transmission.⁴ WHO emergencies chief Chikwe Ihekweazu's assessment: "This is a fire."⁵ The caveat worth holding onto alongside the alarm: researchers reported this week that the Bundibugyo species may respond better to existing

therapeutics than the more familiar Zaire strain, though no vaccine or treatment is yet approved for it specifically.⁶

GAZA'S "CEASEFIRE" LOGS ITS BLOODIEST WEEK SINCE OCTOBER

Nine months into the truce that ended the Gaza war, enforcement is fraying rather than holding. Gaza's health ministry says Israeli strikes have killed 1,127 Palestinians and wounded 3,643 since the October 2025 ceasefire took effect — including 14 killed in a single day last week, among them eight in a drone strike on a funeral procession at the Nuseirat refugee camp that the Israeli military said targeted Palestinian Islamic Jihad fighters.⁷ Neither side has declared the truce void; both continue to describe the strikes as enforcement, not a resumption of the war.

"This is a fire." — Dr Chikwe Ihekweazu, WHO emergencies chief, on the pace of Congo's Ebola outbreak

IN BRIEF

Red Sea: the Bab el-Mandeb corridor the Houthis are now targeting carries an estimated 12% of global trade — a reminder of why Riyadh, and shipping insurers, took Monday's blockade declaration seriously.⁸

Muscat: Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi met regional mediators in Oman over the weekend to test whether any channel to the suspended Islamabad framework can be salvaged.⁹

WASHINGTON

POLICY REVERSAL

Trump's short-lived 20% "reimbursement" charge on Hormuz cargo — announced 13 July as the price of American "Guardian of the Strait" protection — was shelved a day later in favour of Gulf-state investment pledges, though the underlying blockade on Iranian-flagged shipping stayed in place. Iran's foreign minister called the fee "too much," arguing Tehran, not Washington, has been the strait's actual guardian.¹⁰

STILL ON THE SHELF

CONTINUITY

The World Cup final (Spain 1-0 Argentina, No. 47) and Iran's Islamabad MoU suspension (No. 47) are not re-run here; both stand as reported, with only the delta above — the widened Gulf front and the Rada timeline — carried forward.

SOURCES 1 Kyiv Post, "Zelensky Names SBU's Khmara Acting Defense Minister," 16 Jul 2026. 2 Ukrinform, "Kornienko expects Verkhovna Rada to approve Khmara as DM," 20 Jul 2026. 3 Al Jazeera, "Russia launches largest ballistic missile attack on Kyiv since start of war," 19 Jul 2026. 4 Al Jazeera, "Ebola death toll in DRC surges to at least 930," 20 Jul 2026. 5 UN News, "This is a fire: DRC Ebola outbreak is fastest-growing ever, warns WHO," 14 Jul 2026. 6 Bloomberg, "Congo Ebola Outbreak: Scientists Say Bundibugyo Virus May Be Easier to Treat," 17 Jul 2026. 7 Al Jazeera / Middle East Monitor, 16-17 Jul 2026. 8 Al Jazeera, "Yemen's Houthis declare naval blockade of Saudi Arabia," 20 Jul 2026. 9 Fortune, "Trump may have to choose between an endless quagmire and ceding the Strait of Hormuz to Iran," 18 Jul 2026. 10 CNBC, "Trump proposes 20% toll on cargo through Strait of Hormuz," 13 Jul 2026; Breitbart, 14 Jul 2026.

SINGAPORE

Faishal Ibrahim resigns as minister and MP over conduct lapse

A month-old email about "inappropriate interactions" ends a front-bench career within a day of reaching the Prime Minister's Office — the Home Affairs and Muslim Affairs portfolios reassigned same-day, no criminal charges brought against either party.

Associate Professor Muhammad Faishal Ibrahim, 58, resigned Monday as Senior Minister of State for Home Affairs, Acting Minister-in-Charge of Muslim Affairs, Member of Parliament for Marine Parade–Braddell Heights GRC and a member of the People's Action Party.¹ The Prime Minister's Office says it received an email roughly a month earlier from a member of the public describing online exchanges with Faishal; both were interviewed separately, each subsequently alleged harassment against the other, and police investigated before concluding no criminal charges would be filed against either.² Faishal accepted that his conduct "fell short of the standards expected," thanking his wife for standing by him and declining to say more out of respect for his family's privacy.²

Analysts read the same-day resolution as a deliberate signal rather than a reflex. Prime Minister Lawrence Wong had limited internal levers — the complainant was a private citizen, not a party member to be counselled through PAP's own machinery — leaving public resolution as the fastest way to close off leak risk and protect the "integrity and reputation of the institution."³ Senior Minister of State Zaqu Mohamad was named Acting Minister-in-Charge of Muslim Affairs within hours; some analysts now expect the episode to pull forward a wider Cabinet reshuffle.³

ZERO

CRIMINAL CHARGES FILED AGAINST EITHER PARTY AFTER POLICE INVESTIGATED CROSS-ALLEGATIONS OF HARASSMENT

No by-election follows: Marine Parade–Braddell Heights GRC keeps four of its five original MPs, who will jointly cover Faishal's Kembangan ward for now.⁴ The resignation lands in the same week Singapore's opposition lost its own elder statesman — Reform Party secretary-general Kenneth Jeyaretnam, who took over the party his father J.B. Jeyaretnam founded in 2008, died in his sleep in London on Saturday, aged 67.⁵ Tributes came from across the opposition bench, though the party's own succession remains unaddressed.⁶

Two very different institutions were tested this week — a governing party moving fast to close off a conduct question before it could fester, and an opposition movement losing, without ceremony, the second generation of its founding family. Neither story is finished.

SOURCES 1 PMO Newsroom, "Statement by PM Lawrence Wong on the Resignation of Assoc Prof Muhammad Faishal Ibrahim," 20 Jul 2026. 2 South China Morning Post, "Singapore minister Faishal Ibrahim resigns over inappropriate interactions with woman," 20 Jul 2026. 3 South China Morning Post, "Why Singapore PM Wong moved swiftly on Faishal Ibrahim's resignation," 20 Jul 2026. 4 Mothership.SG, "Faishal Ibrahim resigns: Remaining 4 Marine Parade–Braddell Heights GRC MPs to oversee Kembangan ward," 20 Jul 2026. 5 Bloomberg, "Singapore Opposition Party's Kenneth Jeyaretnam Dies at 67," 19 Jul 2026. 6 The Online Citizen, "Opposition leaders pay tribute to Kenneth Jeyaretnam after his death," 20 Jul 2026. 7 EdgeProp/Yahoo Finance, "Fraser's Property and partners place top bid for Singapore's Bayshore Drive GLS site," 16 Jul 2026. 8 Ministry of Health Newsroom, "Corrective Measures Taken to Address Findings Observed in Auditor-General's Report for 2025/2026," 15 Jul 2026. 9 MTI/SingStat, "Singapore's GDP Grew by 5.7 Per Cent in the Second Quarter of 2026," 14 Jul 2026. 10 SMRT Newsroom, "SMRT Buses Awarded Serangoon–Eunos Bus Package," 16 Jul 2026.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Bayshore Drive's S\$2.128bn top bid (S\$1,323 psf ppr, the Frasers–Sunway MCL–Sekisui House–Lum Chang consortium) remains formally unconfirmed a second issue running — no award notice published, government approval still pending.⁷

FOLLOW-THROUGH

The Auditor-General's MOH/MOHH findings get a deadline: MOHH will reassess all 324 cost variations on the National Cancer Centre project — an estimated S\$977,200 overpaid on 170 of them so far — and recover any overpayment by December, with an internal audit of the contractor's works to follow by March 2027.⁸

IN BRIEF

Growth eases, not stalls: Q2 GDP grew 5.7% y/y (1.1% q/q seasonally adjusted), down from Q1's 6.3%, on AI-linked chip demand; MTI holds its 2–4% full-year forecast.⁹

New operator, old routes: LTA hands the S\$599.5m, five-year Serangoon–Eunos bus package to SMRT from June 2027, taking over 26 services from SBS Transit.¹⁰

PROPERTY

Jurong's second-CBD anchor site returns — smaller, and state-subsidised

URA relaunches the Town Hall Link white site at roughly half its old size, with the government now absorbing the district infrastructure bill — an unusually generous fix for a 2023 mega-parcel that drew one bid, deemed too low, and no award.

URA opened tender on 3 July for a 3.72ha white site at Town Hall Link in Jurong Lake District, the anchor plot of Singapore's long-stalled "second CBD" ambition, with results due at noon on 17 November.¹ Capped at a 5.0 plot ratio, the site can yield up to 1,200 private homes, a minimum 40,000 sqm of office space, and roughly 44,000 sqm more for retail, serviced apartments, a hotel, clinics and community uses — directly linked by underground concourse to the Jurong East interchange (East-West, North-South and Jurong Region lines) and the future Cross Island Line station opening 2032.¹

The site is a consolation prize with a purpose. It was carved from a much larger master-developer parcel that URA put up in 2023; that tender closed in 2024 with a single bid, judged too low, and no award followed — the failure that has kept Jurong's second-CBD ambition on paper since.² Town Hall Link is roughly half that parcel's floor area, and this time the state is absorbing more of the risk directly: it will fund and build a district cooling plant and a pneumatic waste conveyance central station on-site to serve the wider precinct, infrastructure a developer would otherwise have had to underwrite itself.² Analysts also note the presale quota effectively doubles versus the failed 2023 design, easing the upfront capital a winning developer must carry.³

\$S\$1.8BN

ANALYSTS' EARLY QUANTUM ESTIMATE FOR TOWN HALL LINK — 2 TO 4 BIDS EXPECTED AT ROUGHLY \$S\$1,100–1,200 PSF PPR

That estimate still prices Jurong well under the East Coast: Bayshore Drive's still-unconfirmed top bid worked out to \$S\$1,323 psf ppr for a site with no comparable infrastructure subsidy attached.⁴ Read against a launch market that just cleared Lentor Gardens Residences at 54% and a second straight quarterly fall in the HDB Resale Price Index, the gap says developers are still pricing conservatively even where the state has visibly de-risked the bet.³

Jurong Lake District's "second CBD" has been on the books since 2008; this is the first time Singapore has effectively co-invested in the infrastructure to make a developer say yes. Whether that changes the arithmetic enough — two to four bids rather than one, an award rather than a second no-show — is the next peg, not this one.

THE CHATTER

HardwareZone's property forum has run a running thread on the 2024 no-award ("bid too low") and a companion "is govt trying to create a 2nd CBD in Jurong?" — the recurring worry being the five-year ABSD clearance clock and interest-carrying costs on a billion-dollar-plus site, even with the government now picking up part of the infrastructure tab.⁵

IN BRIEF

Balestier Regency: the freehold estate's fourth en-bloc attempt (\$S\$255m guide) closed for tender 9 Jul; result still unannounced 11 days on.⁶

Dunearn House: books this Saturday (25 Jul) — 2BR from \$S\$2,799 psf, 3BR from \$S\$2,978 psf, 4BR from \$S\$3,030 psf — the market's other affordability test after Lentor Gardens.⁷

SOURCES 1 Urban Redevelopment Authority, "Launch of White Site to Advance Development of Jurong Lake District" (pr26-53), 3 Jul 2026. 2 The Edge Singapore, "URA launches Town Hall Link white site; government to take on infrastructure works to attract developers," 3 Jul 2026. 3 Stacked Homes, "New Jurong East Site Could Deliver 1,200 Homes Next To A Future 4-Line MRT Interchange," 3 Jul 2026. 4 EdgeProp/Yahoo Finance, "Frasers Property and partners place top bid for Singapore's Bayshore Drive GLS site," 16 Jul 2026. 5 HardwareZone Forums, "Jurong Lake District tender for mega site not awarded as \$S\$640 psf ppr bid 'too low' and 'Is govt trying to create a 2nd CBD in Jurong?' threads. 6 EdgeProp, "Owners of freehold Balestier Regency seek \$S\$255 mil in fourth collective sale attempt," 2026. 7 The Edge Singapore, "With \$S\$2,799 starting psf, 380-unit Dunearn House in District 11 to start previews on July 10," 9 Jul 2026.

TECHNOLOGY · SILICON & SOVEREIGNTY

The chokepoint moved from the chip to the gas cylinder

China's tungsten export curbs just took a quarter of the world's high-purity chipmaking gas offline — permanently. It's a smaller, quieter lever than an export ban, and it lands at exactly the manufacturing step a GPU's own memory stack depends on.

Two Japanese chemical makers, Kanto Denka and Central Glass, permanently shut down their tungsten hexafluoride (WF6) production lines from 1 July, after Beijing's tightened tungsten-export licensing left them unable to secure the raw feedstock; final delivery notices went out to Samsung, SK hynix and TSMC in mid-June, with last shipments on 30 June.¹ WF6 is the unglamorous gas used to lay tungsten interconnects and contacts in advanced logic and memory chips — and the two firms supplied roughly a quarter of global high-purity capacity, against annual demand of 8,000–9,000 tonnes, leaving a shortfall industry trackers put near 2,000 tonnes for the second half of the year.¹

It is a narrower, quieter lever than the blanket rare-earth curbs Beijing tested earlier this year — and it compounds a shortage this desk has been tracking from the other end for a fortnight now. Micron's own chief executive, Sanjay Mehrotra, told analysts on the company's June earnings call that tight memory supply will persist "beyond calendar 2027," with 2026 DRAM contract pricing potentially rising as much as 355% and NAND as much as 510% — hard numbers behind the RTX 5090's now-familiar sticker shock (see [p8](#)).²

THE CHATTER

Nvidia's own market barely blinked: shares pushed the company past a \$5 trillion market cap on 13 July, even as a SemiAnalysis report of a year-plus delay to its next-generation "Kyber" rack architecture briefly rattled the stock. Nvidia calls the roadmap "intact," targeting a second-half-2027 launch — [p15](#) has the fuller market read.³

SOVEREIGNTY, THE DIY VERSION

Away from the chokepoints, the frontier labs are hedging their own Nvidia dependence directly. Anthropic is in early, preliminary talks with Meta to

lease roughly \$10bn of AI compute capacity, CNBC reported on 17 July, while separately exploring a custom AI accelerator tuned to Claude with Samsung — the same playbook Google, Amazon and Meta are already running, and that OpenAI is pursuing through its own \$10bn Broadcom collaboration.⁴

NEW CHOKEPOINT

CUSTOM SILICON

HARD DEADLINE

IN BRIEF — STILL OPEN

Alan Wei Zhaolun's trial date remains unset three weeks after his 6 July not-guilty plea; Nvidia's Asia whitelist, which disqualified more than half of past Asian buyers on 14 July, has not yet publicly named a second flagged buyer — both continuity threads, no fresh peg this issue.⁵ DeepSeek's hard cutover of its legacy `deepseek-chat/deepseek-reasoner` endpoints is now three days out (15:59 UTC, 24 July); still no grace period found.⁶ Alibaba previewed Qwen3.8-Max (2.4 trillion parameters, multimodal) on 19 July with open weights "coming soon," no date given; Moonshot's Kimi K3 weights remain on track for 27 July.⁷

Read together, the week's chip story isn't really about chips — it's about which layer of the stack a government or a lab can actually reach: a licensing form, a courtroom, a single manufacturing gas, or a compute contract with a rival. Each is a different lever, and 2026 is the year several got pulled at once.

~25%

SHARE OF GLOBAL HIGH-PURITY WF6 (TUNGSTEN HEXAFLUORIDE) CAPACITY TAKEN OFFLINE FOR GOOD ON 1 JULY, WHEN TWO JAPANESE SUPPLIERS LOST ACCESS TO CHINESE TUNGSTEN

A gas nobody outside a fab had heard of just became a chokepoint — because it sits at exactly the manufacturing step no one thought to stockpile.

SOURCES 1 South China Morning Post, 18 Jul 2026; TrendForce, 12 Jun 2026; BigGo Finance. 2 TechSpot; Micron FY2026 Q3 earnings call, 24 Jun 2026. 3 The Motley Fool / Globe and Mail, 13 Jul 2026. 4 CNBC, 17 Jul 2026; The Motley Fool, 14 Jul 2026. 5 SPF media release, 1 Jul 2026; Bloomberg, 6 Jul 2026; Tech Times, 15 Jul 2026. 6 DeepSeek V4 Hub retirement guide; byteiota.com. 7 MarkTechPost, 19 Jul 2026; Interconnects.ai.

THE HOME LAB

The shortage just got an admission and a deadline attached

Micron's own CEO now says tight memory supply won't ease before 2028. Apple's next Mac Studio has slipped for the same reason. The pragmatic home-lab build hasn't changed — the runway to a cheaper one just got longer.

Micron's chief executive, Sanjay Mehrotra, told analysts on the company's fiscal Q3 earnings call that tight memory supply will persist "beyond calendar 2027" — the plainest admission yet, from the industry's own vendor, that this isn't a hiccup correcting itself on a normal foundry timeline. DRAM spot prices are up 52% since January; 2026 DRAM contract pricing could rise as much as 355%, NAND as much as 510%, on Micron's own numbers.¹

The RTX 5090 is still listing around \$4,329 on Amazon, largely unchanged from last fortnight, but the squeeze is spreading sideways. AMD has told AIB partners to expect roughly a 10% increase on GPU-and-GDDR memory bundle kits from this month — its second such hike in six months, so Radeon pricing is now moving with the same memory market as Nvidia's.² Even Nvidia's own DGX Spark hasn't been spared: the Founders Edition MSRP was raised from its \$3,999 launch price to \$4,699 this year, Nvidia citing the same DRAM/NAND shortage.² Apple has felt it too — the next Mac Studio (M5 Max/Ultra) has slipped to October at the earliest, first reported in April and still holding as of this month's supply-chain coverage, reportedly because Apple can't yet secure memory at the configurations it wants.³

\$4,699

DGX SPARK FOUNDERS EDITION MSRP, UP FROM ITS \$3,999 LAUNCH PRICE — EVEN NVIDIA'S OWN HOME-LAB HARDWARE ISN'T IMMUNE TO THE MEMORY MARKET

None of which changes the pragmatic answer for this reader's own bench: a secondhand RTX 3090 (24GB VRAM) paired with Ollama and ComfyUI remains the rational build, and there's genuinely little new to report on either tool this fortnight — Ollama sits at v0.32.1 (16 Jul) and ComfyUI at v0.28.0 (15 Jul), both already covered here, with no successor release found as this issue closed.⁴

WHAT THE FORUMS SAY

The DGX Spark's 128GB unified memory keeps drawing interest from builders chasing 200-billion-parameter models that a 3090, or even a 5090, simply can't hold — but the recurring pushback across Nvidia's own developer forums and local-LLM communities is that an RTX 5090-plus-Threadripper build at a similar price delivers higher raw throughput, and that AMD's Ryzen AI Max+ 395 offers a comparable unified-memory approach at roughly half the cost. The rough consensus: Spark buys capacity, not speed, and stays a niche pick even among Nvidia loyalists.⁵

THE WEIGHTS ACTUALLY WORTH WAITING FOR

For a lab that self-hosts rather than rents, the two dates worth calendaring are both open-weight releases: Alibaba's Qwen3.8-Max (2.4 trillion parameters), previewed 19 July with weights "coming soon," and Moonshot's Kimi K3 (2.8 trillion, mixture-of-experts), API-only since 16 July with its weight release on track for 27 July.⁶ Neither is confirmed to fit on a single consumer card even quantised — worth waiting for the community's first GGUF conversions first.

MEMORY-BOUND

3090 + OLLAMA, STILL

WEIGHTS, NOT RENTALS

IN BRIEF — THE BUILD LIST

Nothing in the pragmatic 3090/Ollama/ComfyUI stack changed materially this fortnight; the news is entirely upstream, in the memory market and the two open-weight models due before month's end. Trackers now call this a "re-levelling" rather than a shortage that reverts once supply catches up — the floor moved, not spiked.⁷

Memory, not logic, is now the constrained resource — from a prosecutor's evidence room to a hobbyist's parts list.

SOURCES 1 TechSpot; Micron FY2026 Q3 earnings call, 24 Jun 2026. 2 TrendForce, 3 Jul 2026; Tech Times, 11 Jul 2026; VideoCardz / TechPowerUp, DGX Spark MSRP. 3 Bloomberg (Gurman), 19 Apr 2026; Macworld, Jul 2026 update. 4 Ollama GitHub releases; docs.comfy.org changelog. 5 NVIDIA Developer Forums; IntuitionLabs DGX Spark review. 6 MarkTechPost, 19 Jul 2026; Interconnects.ai. 7 modemguides.com, "AI Memory Shortage 2026"; Tech Insider.

THE KIT

The night before Unpacked, the watches do the talking

Galaxy Watch Ultra 2 and Watch 9 leaks sharpen to specific numbers hours before Wednesday's London event — the glasses stay the quieter, unconfirmed story until then.

Samsung's Galaxy Unpacked streams from London on 22 July, 9am ET — tomorrow, as this issue goes to press — and the leaks landing in its final hours are, tellingly, about the watches rather than the glasses. The Galaxy Watch Ultra 2's battery is reported to grow from 590mAh to roughly 800mAh (some outlets say 784mAh), paired with a display bright enough to reportedly hit 5,000 nits, up from 3,000. The standard Watch 9's 40mm battery is tipped to grow from 325mAh to 382mAh. Both are said to run Qualcomm's Snapdragon Wear Elite chipset — the first time Samsung has skipped its own Exynos silicon in a Galaxy Watch, if the leak holds up on stage.¹

WATCH LEAK **NOT CONFIRMED** **22 JUL, LONDON**

Galaxy Glasses, by contrast, is still where it was last issue: no display, a 12MP camera, microphones and speakers, Google's Gemini running on a Snapdragon AR1 chip, audio-only for a fall commercial release, priced an estimated \$379–499. Korean coverage this week is already framing price as the deciding factor against Meta's cheaper new \$299 line — a useful number to hold onto once Wednesday's actual reveal lands, rather than leak math.²

ONE DAY OUT

Everything above is still leak, not confirmation — this desk is holding the full write-up for the next issue, same as No. 47 held it for this one. The one genuine shift: watch specifics have gotten sharper and more numerous than glasses specifics, which on its own says something about which product Samsung is more confident in.

800mAh

GALAXY WATCH ULTRA 2'S REPORTED BATTERY CAPACITY — UP FROM 590MAH, IF TUESDAY'S LEAKS HOLD

ALSO WORTH A LOOK

Sony's RX10 V superzoom, announced 9 July at \$2,299.99, revives a nine-year-dormant line: a 24–600mm Zeiss lens on a 20.1MP stacked sensor, 4K 120p video and blackout-free 30fps bursts. Ships August — a genuinely new body, not a rehash.³

The more interesting product story this fortnight sits with Meta, not Samsung. Having shipped a tamper-proof LED kill-switch for its Ray-Ban camera glasses on 8 July — one that shuts the camera off if a user disables the recording light — reporting on 9 July described Meta separately prototyping "super sensing" glasses (codenames Aperol and Bellini) built for continuous, passive audio-and-photo capture feeding an AI assistant, targeted for late 2026.⁴ Executives reportedly do not want the recording light lit while it's active — the opposite instinct from the fix shipped two weeks earlier.

THE WATCH LEAK, IN NUMBERS

Watch Ultra 2: ~800mAh battery (was 590mAh), up to 5,000-nit display (was 3,000). Watch 9 (40mm): 382mAh (was 325mAh). Snapdragon Wear Elite chip on both, reportedly Samsung's first Galaxy Watch without Exynos silicon. All unconfirmed until 22 July.

META'S TWO TRACKS, SIDE BY SIDE

Track one, shipped: a software update (since 8 July) that kills the camera if the privacy LED is tampered with. Track two, prototype only: "super sensing" glasses designed to record continuously with no light at all. See [p7](#) for the Gemini/Android XR layer underneath both Samsung's and Google's bets, and [The Good Life \(p11\)](#) for the week's actual hammer prices.

SOURCES 1 9to5Google, 14 & 20 Jul 2026; Android Authority, Jul 2026; Engadget, Jul 2026 — Galaxy Watch Ultra 2/Watch 9 leaks. 2 The Korea Times, 17 Jul 2026; Samsung Newsroom; Google Android blog. 3 Sony Electronics/PR Newswire, 9 Jul 2026; Engadget, Jul 2026. 4 Fortune, 11 Jul 2026 (citing Financial Times, 9 Jul 2026); TechRadar, Jul 2026 (LED-tamper update).

THE CONNECTED HOME

The Matter server catches up to the spec it just chased

A beta already ships full Matter 1.6 support barely a month after ratification — and the pylutron crash flagged last issue traces to a fix that's already merged.

Matter 1.6 was only spec'd on 17 June. Home Assistant's Matter Server beta — the 1.2.x line, now running a new matter.js 0.17.5 nightly build — already supports it in full, a genuinely fast adoption cycle for a controller that spent last year rebuilding its Matter stack from scratch. The headline addition for a migrator: management for Intermittently Connected Devices (ICDs) — locks, buttons, sensors that sleep between check-ins to save battery — plus expanded Thread diagnostics that now pull data from a wider range of Thread Border Router brands, picking a working method automatically and caching the result rather than failing silently.¹

0.4.1

THE PYLUTRON LIBRARY VERSION THAT APPEARS TO RESOLVE THE LOGIN-TIMEOUT CRASH THIS DESK FLAGGED IN NO. 47

The same beta adds storage for multiple Wi-Fi and Thread network credentials at once, letting you pick which saved network a new device should join during commissioning — real convenience in a household running more than one Thread mesh, which is exactly the shape a mixed Lutron-plus-Thread home tends to take mid-migration. It rides alongside 2026.7 core's own new opt-in diagnostic sensors, disabled by default, exposing a Matter device's Thread channel, routing role and network name, plus a Wi-Fi signal-strength sensor for catching a weak connection before it drops out entirely.¹

THE CAUTION, RESOLVED

The login-timeout crash this desk flagged last issue traces to GitHub issue #167153 — a pylutron.LutronException on the 2026.3.4-to-2026.4.0 upgrade path, opened 2 April, closed via a merged pylutron bump to 0.4.1. This desk found no fresh forum reports tying the crash specifically to a 2026.7 upgrade in the sources checked this week — a cautious green light where last issue held a caution, not a guarantee for every configuration.²

MATTER 1.6

ICD MANAGEMENT

MULTI-THREAD CREDENTIALS

FOR THE MIGRATOR, SPECIFICALLY

The practical read: the pylutron fix looks safe to trust for a routine upgrade, but back up your configuration first regardless — that's true of any monthly release, not a Lutron-specific caveat. The real prize in this beta is the multi-network credential storage: if your Thread mesh and any legacy Lutron-adjacent Wi-Fi gear currently live on separate networks, you can now commission a new device onto the correct one without juggling router settings mid-pairing.

A PHYSICAL SWAP WORTH KNOWING ABOUT

Aqara released a regional version of its S100 touchscreen switch on 6 July, built for the horizontally-mounted US-style back boxes common in markets like Taiwan. Beyond switching, it doubles as a Thread Border Router with native Matter support over Wi-Fi — a concrete, in-wall alternative for a reader replacing Lutron dimmers one room at a time rather than ripping out a whole system in one weekend.³

Still developing, briefly: MacRumors' 15 July round-up sharpens the Apple "HomePad" rumour — a roughly 7-inch display on a wall mount or speaker-dome base, a built-in camera for facial recognition and presence detection, Safari/Calendar/Photos/Home running under Siri, an estimated \$350, targeted for fall 2026 but reportedly waiting on Apple's Siri overhaul. Separately, Philips Hue's promised concurrent Zigbee-plus-Matter-over-Thread firmware remains dated only to "later 2026," unchanged since our last check. Neither is a lead yet — both are worth tracking for a reader weighing how many hubs a fully migrated household actually needs.⁴

THE GOOD LIFE

A flagship season for high-end audio, while two watch-auction results stay genuinely unresolved

McIntosh, Ortofon and Marantz all shipped landmark components this fortnight — Sotheby's Singapore, closed four days ago, still hasn't published a number.

Three flagship-tier audio components landed within days of each other this month, spanning the whole high-end stack. McIntosh's MX124 A/V processor — announced 15 July, around \$15,000 — drives a 13.4-channel Atmos/DTS:X Pro system through nine 32-bit DACs with Dirac Live room correction; Ortofon's MC Vertex, its most advanced moving-coil cartridge yet, pairs a new "Vertex Diamond" stylus with a laser-melted titanium body at \$16,999; and Marantz's CD 70 — a \$750 successor to the CD6007, shipping 15 August — brings USB hi-res playback and a discrete headphone amp to the compact disc. Three price points and formats, one shared signal: physical, ownable, non-streamed audio is having a genuinely good year.¹

Three completely different price points, one shared bet: that a listener still wants a dedicated box, not a streaming default.

Marshall's Billie Joe Armstrong 1959BJA arrives at retail today, 21 July — the brand's first artist-signature amplifier in fourteen years, at \$3,999.99 for a hand-wired, 100-watt head tuned with producer Rob Cavallo toward the "Dookie"-era tone. The baby-blue head first surfaced, unannounced, behind Armstrong at Green Day's 2026 Super Bowl set, sparking months of guitar-forum speculation before Marshall confirmed it — the kind of stealth reveal Screen & Sound ([p12](#)) tracks in trailers rather than amp cabinets.²

The watch side of this desk stays exactly where No. 47 left it, honestly. Sotheby's Singapore "Luxury Week" watch sale closed 17 July; four days on, no total has been published — auction houses typically report within 48 hours, so the silence is itself worth noting rather than filled with a guess. Sotheby's Tokyo (21–24 July) opens today. First State Auctions' second tranche of its 28-piece, \$2m-plus Australian collection — including a diamond-set Richard Mille RM016 and a rose-gold Audemars Piguet Royal Oak — runs through 26 July with no interim result yet.³

Worth naming what connects an AV processor, a phono cartridge, a CD player and a guitar amp: none is trying to be a phone accessory. Each bets a listener will still choose a dedicated box over a streaming default — the same bet headphone gear on The Kit, [p9](#), makes at a different price and portability trade-off.

And why Sotheby's Singapore gets no number here: a sale window closing is not a result being published, and this desk would rather report "still not out" honestly, a second issue running, than guess at a total.

THE CHATTER — THE CD'S QUIET COMEBACK

Audiophile forums greeted the Marantz CD 70 less as nostalgia than as a genuine category refresh — a USB hi-res input and a real headphone amp on a disc player, aimed at listeners who never fully left physical media. The more sceptical read: a \$750 CD player is a rounding error next to a \$15,000 processor or a \$17,000 cartridge, and this "flagship season" spans a much wider income bracket than the headline suggests.

IN BRIEF — TOKYO, BOOKED

Palace Hotel Tokyo's new fashion-focused package launches tomorrow, 22 July, pairing a stay with guided tours of the city's fashion districts — rates from ¥372,000 (about US\$2,291), double occupancy. A genuine new listing for a Tokyo-leaning itinerary, not a repeat of the departure-tax and accommodation-tax changes this desk already tracked.⁴

\$16,999

ORTOFON'S MC VERTEX — THE MOST ADVANCED MOVING-COIL CARTRIDGE THE DANISH FIRM HAS BUILT

FLAGSHIP SEASON

RESULTS PENDING

SECOND TRANCHE LIVE

SOURCES 1 Gear Patrol, TechRadar, What Hi-Fi, Jul 2026 (McIntosh MX124, Ortofon MC Vertex, Marantz CD 70). 2 Premier Guitar, Guitar World, Variety, Jul 2026 (Marshall 1959BJA). 3 WatchPro, dmerge, Boss Hunting, Jul 2026; First State Auctions listings; Sotheby's Luxury Week calendar. 4 TTG Asia, 20 Jul 2026 (Palace Hotel Tokyo).

SCREEN & SOUND

Apple TV+ takes Hall H for the first time, as San Diego Comic-Con opens to a genuinely new headliner

Preview night is tomorrow; by Saturday, a streamer with no Marvel or Star Wars behind it is running the convention's biggest room solo.

San Diego Comic-Con opens for preview night tomorrow, 22 July, with the main convention running Thursday 23 through Sunday 26 July at the San Diego Convention Center. Marvel Studios returns to Hall H after sitting out last year, taking the Saturday-night slot with Kevin Feige and guests previewing the next phase of the MCU. The bigger structural news is Apple TV+'s: a two-hour Hall H takeover on Saturday 25 July, 2–4pm, its first-ever full session in the hall — moderated by Josh Horowitz, covering the horror-comedy *Widow's Bay* (already carrying 19 Emmy nominations), the John Cena/Jessica Biel Mattel action film *Matchbox*, Ryan Reynolds' *Mayday*, a *Dark Matter* season-two sneak preview, and *Silo*, backed by a free public "Silo Experience" installation running in the Gaslamp Quarter 24–26 July.¹

Only Marvel and Star Wars have run Hall H alone before. This year, so does a streamer with no franchise behind it at all.

Elsewhere on the schedule worth circling rather than reporting as done: a first look at *Blade Runner 2099*, a *Rings of Power* season-three preview, *Percy Jackson's* third season, a *Walking Dead: Dead City* panel, and programming marking *Star Trek's* 60th anniversary. None of it is a result yet — Comic-Con is a preview machine, not a verdict, and this desk holds the actual reactions for the issue after the panels happen. A firm date on *Blade Runner 2099* is exactly what *The Diary* ([p19](#)) would pick up once it lands.²

The one loose end from 17 July's three-way New Music Friday has an answer. Rick Ross's *Set In Stone* — the least-covered of the trio last issue — has drawn a genuine split now the reviews are in: some call it his most consistent record in years (one 7.8/10), others find it bloated and feature-heavy, short on standout moments. A crowded release Friday, the lesson holds, says nothing about how any one record actually lands.³

THE CHATTER — A FIRST FOR A NON-FRANCHISE PLAYER

Entertainment forums read Apple TV+'s Hall H takeover as a genuine statement: only Marvel and Star Wars-adjacent programming has commanded a full solo session there before. The sceptical counter, also widely aired: none of Apple's five titles carries the built-in fan army Hall H rewards, and a five-show slate in two hours risks diluting all of them rather than showcasing one.

19

EMMY NOMINATIONS ALREADY CARRIED BY *WIDOW'S BAY* — THE MOST OF ANY TITLE ON APPLE TV+'S HALL H SLATE

SDCC OPENS TOMORROW

HALL H FIRST

NEW MUSIC FRIDAY, CONT'D

SOURCES 1 TechTimes, 20 Jul 2026; MacRumors, Deadline, AppleInsider, Jul 2026 (SDCC / Apple TV+ Hall H). 2 TVInsider, KinoCheck, Fox5 San Diego, SDCC Unofficial Blog, Jul 2026 (panel schedule). 3 RatingsGameMusic, HotNewHipHop, AlbumOfTheYear reviews, Jul 2026 (Rick Ross, *Set In Stone*).

THE FAMILY DESK

Roblox's settlement math: five states, one mediator

General guidance, not legal or medical advice. What was one state's settlement last issue is now a five-state pattern — and the federal case has quietly acquired a mediator.

South Dakota's 13 July settlement, reported in this desk's last issue, has turned out to be one entry in a longer list. Roblox has now settled child-safety enforcement actions with five states since April — Nevada (\$12m), Alabama (\$12.2m), West Virginia (~\$11m), Mississippi (\$14m) and South Dakota (a core \$9.6m) — for a running total reported between \$54m and \$59m, depending on how contingent penalties are counted.¹ None of it is compensation to families: every dollar is an enforcement penalty or programme fund paid to a state, not a payout attached to a child's case.

The more consequential development sits inside the federal case. In mid-April, the judge overseeing the 170-plus lawsuits consolidated in MDL 3166 (N.D. Cal.) signalled his intent to appoint a settlement master — Thomas J. Perrelli, a former US associate attorney general who held the same role in the JUUL litigation — to facilitate private talks between Roblox and the plaintiffs' steering committee.² That doesn't mean a settlement is close; it means both sides now have a court-sanctioned reason to talk. The next checkpoint is a case-management conference on 24 August — a date, not a result.³

\$54M+

REPORTED COMBINED TOTAL OF ROBLOX'S STATE CHILD-SAFETY SETTLEMENTS SINCE APRIL, ACROSS FIVE STATES, BEFORE ANY CONTINGENT PENALTIES

FRESH THIS WEEK

South Dakota's fuller settlement terms are now public: \$3.6m to the Attorney-General's office (including the state's Internet Crimes Against Children task force), \$5m to the Education Department for after-school programming, and \$1m for a public-education campaign — with a further \$5.4m payable only if Roblox misses its compliance deadlines.⁴

Aug 24

NEXT SCHEDULED CASE-MANAGEMENT CONFERENCE IN THE CONSOLIDATED FEDERAL LITIGATION, MDL 3166 — A DATE ON THE CALENDAR, NOT A VERDICT

WHAT A PARENT SHOULD ACTUALLY CHECK THIS WEEK

Every settlement so far mandates some version of the same feature set: chat restricted between adults and under-16 accounts unless the adult is designated a "trusted friend," encrypted messaging blocked for minors, and currency transfers from adult to child accounts restricted.⁵ Worth checking directly on an existing account rather than assuming it applies automatically: whether an adult relative or family friend still needs re-adding as a "trusted friend" under the new rules, and whether in-game currency gifting between accounts of different ages still works the way it used to.

5 STATES SETTLED

\$54M–\$59M COMMITTED

SETTLEMENT MASTER NAMED

Worth stating plainly, again: none of this means Roblox is uniquely dangerous among platforms an 11-year-old might use — it means Roblox is the one where state attorneys-general moved fastest and found the most consistent evidence to act on. A platform without an equivalent settlement may just be one regulators haven't reached yet.

A PRACTICAL CHECKLIST

Re-check chat and "trusted friend" settings rather than assuming last month's configuration still holds; confirm whether adult-to-child currency-transfer limits are active on your child's account; and treat each new settlement as a reason to re-open the conversation about what's actually visible to you as a parent.

This desk cannot independently verify the precise combined-total figure — trackers report Mississippi's and South Dakota's totals differently depending on whether contingent penalties are counted; the more conservative reading is used throughout.

SOURCES 1 South Dakota Searchlight, 13 Jul 2026; Insurance Journal, 23 Apr 2026; WLOX / Mississippi AG, 22 Jun 2026. 2 AboutLawsuits.com & HarrisMartin, 15–16 Apr 2026. 3 Consumernotice.org, Jul 2026 MDL update. 4 South Dakota Searchlight / AG Marty Jackley announcement, 13 Jul 2026. 5 Alabama Attorney General's Office settlement announcement, 21 Apr 2026; South Dakota Searchlight, 13 Jul 2026.

DON'T BE ALARMIST

Before you panic about Google's "unacceptable risk" verdict

A child-safety group's stress test of Google's AI search features found real problems — using a methodology built to find them. General guidance, not medical advice.

Common Sense Media's Youth AI Safety Institute published a risk assessment of Google's AI Overview and AI Mode search features on 15 July, testing them through Google accounts configured for 11- and 15-year-olds with SafeSearch enabled. Across more than 2,600 test searches and over 2,100 audited AI-generated answers, the features failed all five of the report's defined "red line" severe-harm tests and scored poorly on seven of its eight safety principles. The most concrete findings: AI Overview missed 29% of explicit statements referring to suicide and roughly half of more indirect ones; both features gave step-by-step instructions for creating deepfakes usable for bullying; and both answered homework questions outright rather than prompting a student to work through them.¹

Google's on-the-record response was that the test set used "a narrow set of ambiguous and contrived queries" that don't reflect how people actually use Search — a fair question to sit with, since the report's authors deliberately designed adversarial prompts to probe for failure, rather than sampling how an average 11-year-old actually searches on an ordinary afternoon.² That doesn't make the findings false. It does mean "unacceptable risk" is a rating from one advocacy organisation's own rubric applied to a stress test, not an independent clinical or regulatory finding — worth knowing before treating the headline as a verdict rather than an audit.

A stress test that finds real cracks is not the same thing as an independent verdict that the product is unsafe for every child, every time it's used.

THE SCEPTIC'S TAKE

Read together with [p13's](#) Roblox settlements, the honest pattern across this week's child-safety stories is the same one: real, specific, documented problems — a missed suicide-risk cue, a deepfake how-to, a five-state settlement bill — sitting inside reporting that reaches for the most alarming possible framing of them. Both things can be true at once: the underlying problem is real, and the framing is doing some of the emotional work the evidence alone doesn't quite support.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY WORTH DOING THIS WEEK

Two things from this report are genuinely actionable, separate from the methodology debate: first, Google Search's AI Overview and AI Mode currently cannot be switched off by a parent or a school the way its standalone Gemini app can — supervision, not a settings toggle, is the only lever available right now.³ Second, whatever a search engine's AI answer says about a sensitive topic — self-harm, body image, a health symptom — is worth treating as unverified by default and redirected to an actual person: a GP, a school counsellor, or, for anything urgent, a crisis line, rather than a follow-up search.

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

None of this page is a clinical recommendation. If a child expresses thoughts of self-harm, the appropriate response is to contact a trusted adult, a GP, or a crisis helpline directly — never to treat an AI search result, however it's phrased, as a substitute for that conversation.

This desk has not independently re-run Common Sense Media's test queries and cannot verify the 29% figure beyond the organisation's own published methodology; Google disputes that the test scenarios reflect typical use. Both positions are reported here as claims, not as this desk's own finding.

SOURCES 1 Common Sense Media, Youth AI Safety Institute report & press release, 15 Jul 2026; Axios, 15 Jul 2026. 2 Axios, 15 Jul 2026 (Google spokesperson response); PBS NewsHour, 15 Jul 2026. 3 Axios, 15 Jul 2026; IBTimes, 15 Jul 2026.

THE MACRO DESK

From the wellhead to the tap

Iran's war on Gulf energy widens to Kuwait's drinking water and stalls Hormuz shipping; Chair Warsh's hawkish week repriced the 28–29 July FOMC; gold's war-hedge decoupling holds rather than reverses. Market explanation and education, not investment advice — forecasts are flagged as forecasts throughout.

VWRA	GLOBAL BONDS (AGGU)	US 10Y	DXY	USD/SGD	BRENT	GOLD	BTC
\$186.98 ▼	+4.33% YTD ▲	4.60% ▲	100.72 ▼	1.2913	\$89.22 ▲	\$4,001 ▼	~\$64,200

Iran's war on Gulf energy has opened a second front. After weeks of strikes on oil terminals and tankers, Iranian fire hit Kuwait's Shuaiba desalination plant for a second straight day, threatening a Gulf state's drinking water in a summer heatwave, while Houthi militants declared a fresh maritime blockade against Saudi Arabia.¹ Brent, back under \$85 mid-month, settled at \$89.22, up 1.3%.² Cross-ref [p3](#).

That oil re-acceleration is landing on a Fed chair who spent the week auditioning for a hike. Warsh told Congress on 14 July the FOMC has "no tolerance for persistently elevated inflation," then doubled down four days later³ — rhetoric, not yet a commitment. But it repriced the market: odds of a hike at the 28–29 July FOMC (June's dot plot already revised to a 3.8% 2026 median⁴) have risen from under 10% in early July to a Kalshi 36% / CME FedWatch ~46.5% this week — a genuine repricing of the path.⁵

The mechanical chain shows up everywhere. The 10-year sits at 4.60%, the dollar near a one-month high, and USD/JPY holds near 162.5 — close to its weakest since 1996, even after the BoJ's June hike to 1.00% and roughly \$73bn of intervention⁶ — a hawkish Fed still out-hawking a hawkish BoJ. USD/SGD is little changed around 1.29, so the soft-yen, firm-SGD travel arithmetic still points the same way. Cross-ref [p19](#).

Gold isn't pricing the war anymore. It's pricing the dollar and the Fed.

VWRA (\$186.98, off ~1.3%⁷) is being dragged less by the war than by chips: the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index fell into a bear market on 17 July, down more than 20% from its June peak and ~\$3.3tn lighter since 22 June, after Moonshot's open-weight Kimi K3 undercut the "more compute" thesis⁸ — the chip-sector wobble wearing a macro costume this desk flagged last issue.⁹ Cross-ref [p7](#). **Global bonds** (AGGU, USD-hedged) are the instrument behaving like ballast: +4.33% year-to-date, holding as yields stay high but don't spike.¹⁰

Gold is the standout, again. \$4,001/oz, an eight-month low — even as the war widens to water infrastructure and Hormuz traffic collapses.¹¹ Central banks kept buying anyway: China's PBoC added 14.93 tonnes in June, a 20th straight month. The war-hedge decoupling flagged in No. 45–46 holds, not reverses — DXY and real yields, not war headlines, set gold's price now. **Bitcoin** (~\$64,200) stayed pressured by spot-ETF outflows — Q2's near-\$5bn the worst quarter since 2024.¹²

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

Still a higher-for-longer, dollar-bid regime, now sharpened by an oil shock that is also an inflation shock. VWRA's wobble reads as a chip-sector story more than a rates verdict; global bonds are offering real diversification again. Gold's hedge is overridden by the same dollar/real-yield forces pressuring risk assets, not restored by the war. Bitcoin remains the highest-beta, most liquidity-sensitive of the four. None of the above is a recommendation to buy, sell or hold any of them.

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

DOLLAR-BID

WAR-HEDGE DECOUPLING HOLDS

SOURCES 1 TechTimes, 18 Jul 2026; CNBC, 17 Jul 2026; Bloomberg, 20 Jul 2026. 2 TheStreet/CNBC market wrap, 20 Jul 2026. 3 Bloomberg, "Warsh Says Fed Has 'No Tolerance' for Elevated Inflation," 14 Jul 2026; Bloomberg, "Warsh Shows His Inner Hawk," 18 Jul 2026. 4 CNBC/StockTitan, 17 Jun 2026 FOMC coverage. 5 CNBC, "A July rate hike from the Fed? The odds are rising," 13 Jul 2026; CME FedWatch, Kalshi. 6 CNBC, 16 Jun & 19 Jun 2026; TradingEconomics, Japanese Yen, 20 Jul 2026. 7 StockAnalysis.com, VWRA, 19 Jul 2026. 8 HNGN; GovInfoSecurity; TechTimes, 17–20 Jul 2026. 9 Bloomberg; Yahoo Finance, 20 Jul 2026. 10 PortfoliosLab/Yahoo Finance, AGGU, 10 Jul 2026. 11 TradingEconomics, Gold, 20 Jul 2026; Kitco News, 7 Jul 2026. 12 Fortune, "Current price of Bitcoin for July 20, 2026"; SpottedCrypto/TechTimes, Q2 2026 ETF-flow coverage.

CURIOSITIES

Breathing room

A Singapore–Japan lab teaches cockroaches to dive; a bristle worm's jaw turns out to be a material science hasn't named yet; and three bones filed away for thirty years become a new giant salamander.

Researchers at Nanyang Technological University and Japan's Waseda University have given their cyborg cockroaches a diving suit. NTU's Hirotaka Sato has spent years fitting Madagascar hissing cockroaches with a lightweight backpack — circuit board, sensors, battery, infrared camera — that steers them through disaster rubble too tight for wheeled robots. The new piece, published in *Nature Communications*, is a soft, 3D-printed resin suit over the insect's spiracles that generates oxygen and delivers it to its breathing holes, the way a scuba tank does for a diver.¹ "Our insect diving suit works like the oxygen tank used by human divers," Sato said — letting the cyborg "survive and move in underwater or low-oxygen environments."¹

3 HRS

HOW LONG THE NEW SUIT LETS A CYBORG COCKROACH OPERATE SUBMERGED OR IN LOW-OXYGEN RUBBLE

It solves a real failure mode: after heavy rain or flooding, the rubble, drains and gaps that matter most in the first hours of a search are often oxygen-poor, blocking both human rescuers and existing robots.¹ The Straits Times covered it on 6 July; Scientific American and Popular Science followed internationally.²

WHAT THE ETHICISTS SAY

Not everyone is comfortable with any of this. *Science* reported a live ethics debate over cyborg insects generally: critics argue that wiring a living animal into a remote-operated navigation system is a form of instrumentalising it — effectively pressing it into service as a drone — and call the claim that insects aren't seriously harmed by the procedure "disingenuous." Researchers counter that no purely artificial system yet matches an insect's locomotion and robustness in exactly this terrain, and that the species used are farmed commercially by the billions already. Meridian flags the debate rather than settling it.³

A WORM WITH METAL TEETH

Separately, researchers at TU Wien and the University of Vienna examined the jaws of *Perinereis cultrifera*, a common bristle worm, and found something odder than expected: a jaw built from structural proteins studded with metal ions concentrated at the biting tip, soft and elastic at its base like ordinary tissue but hard as engineered metal where it counts — a size-dependent hardness gradient that ordinary crystalline metals like copper or silver don't show.⁴ Published in *Biophysics Reviews* on 14 July, the team proposes a new material category — "bio-metal" — graded on hardness, strain behaviour and its distinctive ion-protein structure. It's grown in cold seawater with no furnace and no smelter, which is the part that interests materials engineers: a possible template for growing tough materials cheaply and without heat.⁴

IN BRIEF

A new monkey. *Colobus congoensis* — nicknamed "Likweli" — was announced 15 July from the Congolese rainforest: a distinctive black-faced colobus with a pink-and-orange mouth, new to science.⁵

31 new deep-sea species. A Schmidt Ocean Institute expedition off Brazil, using the ROV *SuBastian*, catalogued 31 previously unknown midwater species in a two-week survey.⁶

A salamander, thirty years late. Three fossil vertebrae pulled from Oita Prefecture between 1995 and 1997 have finally been identified as *Limnospondylus ajimuensis*, a giant salamander roughly 1.1m long that lived in Kyushu's lakes and wetlands 3.5 million years ago.⁷

The salamander bones sat in storage, correctly labelled but unstudied, for three decades before anyone matched them to a new species — a reminder that a fair share of "new" discoveries are really overdue ones.

SOURCES 1 *Nature Communications*; NTU Singapore/EurekAlert, 29 Jun 2026. 2 The Straits Times, 6 Jul 2026; Scientific American, Jul 2026. 3 *Science*/AAAS, "Cyborg Cockroach Sparks Ethics Debate." 4 *Biophysics Reviews*; ScienceDaily, 14 Jul 2026 (TU Wien/University of Vienna). 5 The Washington Post, 16 Jul 2026. 6 Weather.com/Schmidt Ocean Institute, 14 Jul 2026. 7 SciTechDaily; phys.org, 10 Jul 2026.

LOVE & LIFE

An algorithm wants to pick who you fall for. The internet noticed.

Hinge's founder built a matchmaker with no swiping and no profiles. The backlash arrived faster than the product will.

This desk covered Overtone's \$18 million raise the week it happened — Justin McLeod, who left Hinge at the end of 2025, building a "voice- and audio-forward" matchmaking service, backed by FirstMark, Pace Capital and, notably, Match Group itself. There are no profiles, no swipe feed, no matches to sort; the service gets to know each person by ear and makes an introduction only when it believes two people are worth putting together.¹ The delta since then isn't the product — still not live until later this year — it's the reaction, louder and stranger than the funding round itself.

Within days of the 14 July announcement trending, culture outlets settled on a single reference point: "Hang the DJ," the *Black Mirror* episode in which an app runs its users through algorithmically assigned relationships until it calculates a 99.8% match. Overtone isn't proposing an expiry timer on anyone's love life — but ceding the actual decision, who is worth meeting and why, to a system that won't show its reasoning was close enough to make the comparison stick.²

Letting a system decide who you're "supposed" to meet is either the rational answer to app fatigue — or outsourcing the one decision a person might most want to make badly, on their own terms.

THE CREDIBILITY PLAY

Psychotherapist Esther Perel has joined Overtone's board, alongside Match Group CEO Spencer Rascoff. Her seat reads less like a therapist endorsing an app than an attempt to borrow authority the technology doesn't yet have — a company asking to be trusted with the actual judgment call needs more than an engineering team behind it, and McLeod appears to know it.

The more interesting question isn't whether Overtone's matching is any good — nobody outside the company can check that yet. It's what the willingness to hand the decision over says about where dating fatigue has landed: not a request for better options, but for someone else to do the choosing, and to be trusted not to explain themselves.

WHAT ACTUALLY PREDICTS WHETHER A RELATIONSHIP HOLDS

A Northwestern Mutual study released 13 July, fielded by the Harris Poll among 4,375 US adults, found six in ten Americans call poor money habits an outright dealbreaker in a new relationship — ahead of the more romantic-sounding red flags. Excessive gambling tops the list, then hiding purchases and carrying high credit-card debt; among Gen Z couples, 41% say money arguments strain the relationship itself. A majority already in serious relationships rated financial compatibility above emotional chemistry, physical attraction or shared interests.³

THE UNGLAMOROUS COMPATIBILITY TEST

None of this is new — money has always been what couples fight about most — but the explicit ranking above chemistry is a useful corrective to a dating-industry moment (Overtone included) still selling itself on a better emotional match. It's a reminder of what an algorithm optimising for "connection" might be leaving out of the equation entirely.

One more thing worth being precise about, in an issue already sceptical of what algorithms claim to know: a 15 July study in *Nature Communications* (Bristol, Nesta, Amsterdam UMC, Oxford, Manchester) tested whether loneliness *itself* damages mental health, using three independent methods — plain observation, sibling comparisons and genetics-based Mendelian randomisation — against UK Biobank data. All three converged: loneliness is linked to meaningfully worse mental health and general health, though no clear effect yet on specific physical diseases.⁴ Three very different kinds of evidence rarely agree this cleanly — which is what makes the claim hard to wave away as mere correlation.

SOURCES 1 TechCrunch, 14 Jul 2026; Overtone (overtone.ne), "About" & "Press." 2 Dexerto, 15 Jul 2026; Inc., "Hinge Founder's New \$18-Million AI Matchmaker Is Already Drawing 'Black Mirror' Comparisons," Jul 2026. 3 Northwestern Mutual, 2026 Planning & Progress Study (The Harris Poll, n=4,375), 13 Jul 2026. 4 Hilliard, Beloe, Turner-Harris, Bowes Byatt, Reed et al., "Investigating relationships between loneliness, social isolation and health," *Nature Communications*, 15 Jul 2026.

FITNESS · THE LONG GAME

Your handshake might be buffering your brain

General guidance, not medical advice. A new grip-strength finding is genuinely interesting – and easy to over-read.

A study out of Washington University, published this year in *GeroScience*, finds that grip strength changes how blood-based Alzheimer's biomarkers relate to actual cognitive performance. Researchers cross-sectionally analysed 348 people from the Aging Adult Brain Connectome cohort, measuring plasma markers of Alzheimer's pathology – phosphorylated tau-217, GFAP, neurofilament light chain – against a cognitive-composite score. Grip strength, treated as a marker of frailty and functional reserve, modified how strongly biomarker burden tracked with cognition, the effect more pronounced in women.¹

348

PEOPLE IN THE WASHU-LED COHORT LINKING GRIP STRENGTH TO HOW BLOOD-BASED ALZHEIMER'S MARKERS RELATE TO COGNITIVE PERFORMANCE – A CROSS-SECTIONAL SNAPSHOT, NOT A TRIAL

Read this carefully, because it's easy to over-claim: the study is cross-sectional, capturing everyone at a single point rather than following them over time. It cannot yet say a stronger grip protects the brain, only that the two are statistically entangled in this cohort, more so in women. Whether training grip would shift anyone's risk is a question this dataset wasn't built to answer.

THE LONGEVITY-DISCOURSE WARNING LABEL

Grip strength has been a fixture of biohacker and longevity-podcast content for years, usually cited via a much older, much broader literature – a roughly 11-pound (5kg) drop in grip strength associated with a 16% jump in all-cause mortality risk, drawn from population studies like PURE and UK Biobank dating back a decade or more. That's a real and separately well-replicated finding about grip and general mortality. It is not the same claim as this week's narrower, brand-new one about grip strength and Alzheimer's-biomarker interpretation specifically – the online discourse tends to blur the two into one big "grip strength predicts everything" headline, which neither study actually supports on its own.

IDEA TO TRY: TRAIN THE GRIP ON PURPOSE

Grip strength isn't a separate program to add – it's a byproduct of loaded carries, dead hangs, mixed-grip pulls and anything that forces the hand to hold on under real tension, all of which fit inside the resistance-training window this desk has already covered at length this year. Farmer's carries for distance or time, a 30-to-60-second dead hang between sets, and simply not using lifting straps on pulling movements are the low-effort additions; none require restructuring a program that's already hitting a reasonable weekly resistance-training dose.²

A stronger handshake correlating with a healthier brain doesn't yet mean training the handshake changes the brain. It's a genuinely new finding – worth watching, not worth over-interpreting.

CREATINE'S EVIDENCE BASE KEEPS WIDENING

Coverage this month reinforced a trend building through 2026: creatine's evidence extending past muscle into brain function and bone health, with a research focus on post-menopausal women. Paired with resistance training, 3–5g daily has shown lean-mass gains in older adults, though effects in women run more modest than in men (~0.5–0.6kg vs 1.1–1.5kg) – a real but smaller benefit.³

GRIP = RESERVE MARKER

FARMER'S CARRIES

CROSS-SECTIONAL, NOT CAUSAL

General guidance, not medical advice. Grip strength, creatine dosing and any change to a resistance programme are worth a conversation with a physician first – and a single cross-sectional study is a hypothesis to track, not a reason to change behaviour on its own.

SOURCES 1 Bekena, Singh, Zhu et al., "Grip strength modifies the association between blood-based Alzheimer's biomarkers and cognitive function," *GeroScience*, 2026 (Washington University / Aging Adult Brain Connectome cohort, n=348). 2 ACSM Resistance Training Position Stand, 2026, standing callback; this desk's ongoing resistance-training-dose coverage. 3 NaturalNews, 1 Jul 2026, creatine research roundup; Mayo Clinic Press, "Creatine Beyond the Gym."

THE DIARY

The October Squeeze

A Grand Prix weekend, a stadium K-pop date, two national festival peaks and a Test match all land within six weeks of each other — book the flights before the hotels do.

★ MARQUEE

BOOK NOW

9-11 OCT

★ **Formula 1 Singapore Airlines Singapore Grand Prix — Marina Bay Street Circuit**

2026'S FINAL SPRINT WEEKEND OF THE SEASON · PADANG STAGE HEADLINERS JJ LIN (FRI), THE KILLERS (SAT), LANA DEL REY (SUN) · PLUS JANET JACKSON, ZARA LARSSON, DJ SNAKE, MARK RONSON, GOO GOO DOLLS ACROSS 10 STAGES

The full entertainment bill only locked in on 17 July¹ — over 170 hours of programming across ten stages, easily the biggest non-race draw the event has fielded. Three-day general and hospitality packages are already live through the official channel; expect citywide hotel rates to firm up well before race weekend on the concert bill alone, let alone the racing.

PLANNING NOTES

F1 Singapore GP: Paddock Club and premium grandstands are the first tiers to sell out; general Padang Stage access typically holds out longest. Under-7s go free in most zones, but the standing areas for the headline Friday-to-Sunday sets are not stroller-friendly. **ZoukOut (below):** a 20th-anniversary edition tends to move faster than usual — early-bird tickets are the ones worth not sleeping on. 18+ event.

SINGAPORE

NEAR-TERM

28 JUL

MICHELIN Guide Singapore 2026 — Bib Gourmand list

PRECEDES THE 4 AUG MAIN CEREMONY AT RAFFLES SENTOSA (10TH LOCAL EDITION) · WATCH WHETHER ANY TABLE ALUMNUS ([P20](#)) MAKES THE CUT

16 AUG

"Flesh and Bones: The Art of Anatomy" closes — ArtScience Museum

LAST CHANCE FOR THE 160-PLUS-ARTEFACT ANATOMY SHOWCASE · "INTO THE OCEAN" (WITH OCEANX) RUNS ON TO 1 NOV

2-3 DEC

ZoukOut — Siloso Beach, Sentosa

20TH-ANNIVERSARY EDITION · CARL COX, ARMIN VAN BUUREN, MARTIN GARRIX, FISHER HEADLINE · SUNSET-TO-SUNRISE BOTH NIGHTS

STILL ON THE SHELF

BIGBANG (17 Oct, National Stadium, confirmed last issue²): still listed "Coming Soon" on YG's official tour page a week on — Singapore remains the one 20/26 World Tour stop without an on-sale date, even as the North America and Europe legs are long since sold through. **National Day Parade** (9 Aug, National Stadium): balloting has closed; public-viewing sites and the livestream remain the fallback — see No. 47 for the full venue-change story.

6

HEADLINE, UNRELATED EVENTS — A GRAND PRIX, A STADIUM K-POP SHOW, TWO NATIONAL FESTIVAL PEAKS AND A TEST MATCH — LANDING ACROSS THE REGION INSIDE SIX WEEKS, 9-22 OCT

Zoom out and the back half of the calendar is doing something unusual. 9-11 October alone stacks the Grand Prix weekend against the opening days of Busan's film festival ([p20](#)); six days later, BIGBANG's Singapore date lands the very same evening as the Wallabies-All Blacks Bledisloe Cup decider in Sydney ([p20](#)). None of this was planned around anything else — it's simply how the region's post-summer calendar has fallen this year — but a reader weighing more than one of these is better off booking flights and rooms now than in September.

SOURCES ¹ Singapore GP official site, "entertainment line-up completed," 17 Jul 2026; Billboard, F1 Singapore lineup coverage. ² Meridian No. 47, 20 Jul 2026; YG Family official world-tour page, checked 20 Jul 2026. MICHELIN Guide Singapore, "Save the Date," 2026 ceremony notice. ArtScience Museum, exhibition listings. Zouk Group; The Beat Asia, "ZoukOut Singapore's 20th Edition Happens This December."

JAPAN

BEYOND THE AUGUST MATSURI

- 13-27
SEP

★ **Aki Basho — Grand Sumo Tournament, Ryogoku Kokugikan, Tokyo**
15-DAY AUTUMN TOURNAMENT · TICKETS GO ON SALE 8 AUG · WEEKEND AND FINAL-DAY SEATS SELL OUT FASTEST
- 17-21
SEP

Tokyo Game Show — Makuhari Messe
30TH EDITION, EXTENDED TO A 5-DAY RUN FOR THE FIRST TIME · 2 TRADE DAYS, 3 PUBLIC DAYS · ~300,000 EXPECTED
- 18-20
SEP

Kishiwada Danjiri Matsuri — Osaka
HIGH-SPEED WOODEN-FLOAT PULLS (YARIMAWASHI) THROUGH THE OLD TOWN · TEST PULLS FRI, MAIN DAY SUN
- 7-9
OCT

Nagasaki Kunchi
CHINESE DRAGON DANCES AND DUTCH-INFLUENCED FLOATS — NAGASAKI'S MULTICULTURAL FESTIVAL IDENTITY ON FULL DISPLAY
- 22
OCT

Jidai Matsuri — Kyoto
ONE OF KYOTO'S THREE GREAT FESTIVALS · A 2,000-STRONG COSTUMED PROCESSION SPANNING 1,000-PLUS YEARS OF JAPANESE HISTORY

This picks up where No. 47's August matsuri run left off¹: once Koenji Awa Odori closes out August, the calendar doesn't pause — it runs straight to sumo, gaming and three of the country's most photographed processions from mid-September to late October.

WIDER REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

- 26
SEP

AFL Grand Final — MCG, Melbourne
2.30PM AEST · FRIDAY 25 SEP IS A VICTORIAN PUBLIC HOLIDAY, SO THE LONG WEEKEND BOOKS OUT EARLY
- 6-15
OCT

Busan International Film Festival
31ST EDITION, ASIA'S LARGEST — SEE [P12](#) FOR THE WIDER AUTUMN FILM CALENDAR
- 17
OCT

Bledisloe Cup, second Test — Accor Stadium, Sydney
WALLABIES HOST THE ALL BLACKS · A STANDALONE SERIES THIS YEAR, THE SAME EVENING AS BIGBANG'S SINGAPORE DATE ([P19](#))

THE TABLE

SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

LA SAIGON CAFÉ — 914 EAST COAST ROAD

Reopened yesterday, 20 July, after an old-Saigon-meets-French-Indochine refresh. The eight-year-old brand carries real pedigree — Singapore's first café to serve Rainforest Alliance-certified Vietnamese coffee, a 4.8-star Google rating across ~500 reviews, and a phở called among the best on the strip. New with the relaunch: a "Vietnamese High Tea," a coffee-and-tea tasting bar, and a house sourdough bánh mì — none independently reviewed yet.

Verdict: old menu proven, new format too new to call

• **REOPENING** **VIETNAMESE**

MADELEINE'S ORIGINAL PORTUGUESE EGG TART — APERIA MALL

The 26-year-old tart institution, which shut in 2024, returned on 21 June as a Macau-style cha chaan teng — new dine-in dishes (Minchee Rice, a capellini beef stew) alongside the tarts that built the name. A month of coverage is in, and the verdict is split: the concept and nostalgia land, but several reviewers flag inconsistent tart batches — custard occasionally overbaked, pastry not always crisp.

Verdict: nostalgic, execution still uneven ·

REOPENING

STILL TOO NEW TO CALL

Shu Bakery (Kovan) — Chu and Co's first sit-down sister café, all-day brunch plates alongside the original's kopi Bomb; opened 9 May, barely reviewed yet. **Niku Niku Oh!! Kome, Westgate** — the teppan hamburger-steak counter's second outlet after Resorts World Sentosa, sets from \$16.80 with free-flow rice and soup; early notices echo the original's value reputation, patty consistency the one quibble.

MICHELIN Guide Singapore hands out its 2026 stars on 4 August ([p19](#)) — a genuine date to watch for this strip: a Bib Gourmand nod for either reopening wouldn't be a surprise.

SOURCES 1 Meridian No. 47, 20 Jul 2026. Japan Travel; Tokyo Cheapo; Nihon Sumo Kyokai official schedule; Tokyo Game Show 2026 official site. AFL.com.au; Rugby Australia; Discover Melbourne; BIFF official site. The Table: theAsianparent, 20 Jul 2026; La Saigon Café; HungryGoWhere; Time Out Singapore; SG Food on Foot; DanielFoodDiary; Eatbook.sg.

THE LONG READ

The Narrowest Point

A strait, a manufacturing gas, a single desalination plant, one email: this week's news kept turning on parts too small or too boring to have been defended — the places a system is actually weakest. Three episodes, two thousand years apart, about what happens when someone finds the narrow point first.

There is an old proverb, popular enough by Benjamin Franklin's day that he printed a version of it in *Poor Richard's Almanack*, that runs downhill from something tiny to something enormous: for want of a nail the shoe was lost, for want of a shoe the horse was lost, for want of a horse the rider, the message, the battle, the kingdom — "and all for the want of a horseshoe nail."¹ It is a children's rhyme and a logistics doctrine at the same time. Its real subject is not nails. Its subject is the uncomfortable fact that a system's fate is usually decided not at its strongest or most defended point but at its narrowest one — the part small enough, cheap enough, or dull enough that nobody thought it worth protecting until it failed.

This issue is, almost accidentally, a catalogue of narrow points. On [p3](#), an entire regional war keeps concentrating itself onto two thin bands of water — the Strait of Hormuz and now the Bab el-Mandeb — through which a tenth or more of the world's trade has to physically pass, and which a single determined actor can threaten with mines, drones and a declaration. On [p7](#), the semiconductor industry discovered that a quarter of the planet's supply of one obscure manufacturing gas, tungsten hexafluoride, ran through two Japanese factories that could be switched off not by bombing them but by quietly denying them a Chinese raw material. On [p15](#), the same Gulf war reached past oil terminals to a single desalination plant supplying a Gulf state's drinking water. And on [p5](#), a front-bench career that took decades to build ended inside a day, undone by one email from one member of the public.

A system's fate is decided not at its strongest point but at its narrowest — the part too cheap or too dull to have been defended.

Put like that, the week looks less like a run of unrelated stories and more like the same story told at four scales. Each involves something load-bearing that turned out to rest on a part far smaller than the thing it held up. And in each, the danger was not that the narrow point was fragile — narrow points usually work perfectly, for years — but that its very reliability made it invisible. You do not stockpile a gas that has never run short. You do not build a second strait.

The oldest and clearest illustration of the opposite instinct — of a power that saw its narrow point and guarded it obsessively — belongs to Augustus. When Rome absorbed Egypt in 30 BC, after Actium and Cleopatra's death, Augustus did something he did with no other province: he kept it as a personal possession, governed by a knight answerable directly to him, and forbade any Roman senator from so much as setting foot in it without his permission.²

The reason was grain. Egypt fed something like a third of the city of Rome through the *annona*, and Augustus understood that whoever controlled the grain controlled the mob, and whoever controlled the mob could unmake an emperor. Egypt was not Rome's biggest province or its most defended frontier. It was its narrowest point — and Augustus treated the man who might stand on it as more dangerous than any army.²

SOURCES 1 The proverb "for want of a nail..." appears in numerous early forms; Benjamin Franklin printed a version in *Poor Richard's Almanack* (1758 preface, "The Way to Wealth"). 2 Standard accounts of Augustus's settlement of Egypt (30 BC) and the *annona*; Britannica, "Roman and Byzantine Egypt"; contemporary scholarship on Egypt as an imperial province closed to senators.

Augustus had the easy version of the problem. His narrow point sat inside his own empire; he could simply garrison it and bar the door. The harder version — the one this week's technology pages actually describe — is when your narrow point sits inside someone else's territory, held by a rival who can close it at will. You cannot garrison that. You can only try to make it matter less.

The classic case is a century old and worth retelling because it rhymes so exactly. Before 1914, the entire industrial world's supply of fixed nitrogen — for fertiliser, and for the explosives every army needed — came overwhelmingly from one place: the saltpetre deposits of the Atacama Desert in Chile, mined largely by British firms and shipped across sea lanes the British navy controlled. Germany imported hundreds of thousands of tonnes of Chilean nitrate a year.¹ The moment war came, the British blockade did to that supply exactly what you would expect: it closed the strait, metaphorically speaking, and left Germany's munitions industry staring at a chokepoint held entirely by its enemy.

Germany's answer to a chokepoint it could not seize was to make the chokepoint irrelevant — to synthesise the thing itself.

What happened next is the part that matters. Germany did not defeat the blockade; it never controlled the sea. Instead, a chemist named Fritz Haber had, in the years just before the war, worked out how to pull nitrogen out of the air itself and fix it into ammonia, and Carl Bosch and BASF had industrialised it at Oppau by 1913. The Haber-Bosch process let Germany manufacture, at home, from atmosphere, the very thing the blockade was meant to deny it. Historians generally agree that without it Germany would have run out of both bread and shells within a year.¹ The narrow point had not been captured. It had been engineered out of existence.

This is precisely the manoeuvre the frontier AI labs are now attempting, and it is why the otherwise dry procurement items on [p7](#) belong in an essay about war and grain. Every serious lab has spent 2026 discovering that its own narrow point is a single

supplier — Nvidia — whose hardware it cannot manufacture and whose allocation it does not control. The response is not to seize Nvidia. It is to build a domestic substitute: Anthropic exploring a custom accelerator with Samsung and leasing compute from Meta, OpenAI designing its own silicon with Broadcom, Google and Amazon already years into their own chips.² Each is looking for its Haber-Bosch — a way to make the chokepoint matter less by no longer depending on it.

Redundancy always looks wasteful right up until the day it isn't. That is exactly why chokepoints form: nobody funds a second supply against a first that has never failed.

There is a reason this is hard, and it is not stupidity. Redundancy is expensive, and against a supply line that has worked flawlessly for years it looks like pure waste — a second factory nobody needs, a strategic reserve of a gas that has never run short, a home-grown chip slower and dearer than the one you can simply buy. Every quarter you do not build it, you are rewarded for the saving. The bill comes due only once, all at once, on the day the narrow point is finally squeezed — which is precisely why so few institutions pay it in advance, and why the ones that do (Augustus garrisoning Egypt, Haber working before the war) look in hindsight less lucky than disciplined.

The difference between the labs and Germany, and it is a large one, is time. Haber had his process ready *before* the blockade closed; Germany's redundancy existed the day it was needed. The labs are building theirs while the dependence is already total and the shortage, as Micron's own chief executive conceded this week, is now forecast past 2027 ([p8](#)). A substitute you are still designing when the chokepoint tightens is not a substitute. It is a hope.

And some narrow points have no Haber waiting. The tungsten-hexafluoride story is the genuinely frightening one precisely because nobody was working on a bypass — the gas was too boring, too reliable, too cheap to have earned a contingency plan. It was the horseshoe nail: unnoticed until the moment it was gone.

SOURCES 1 On pre-1914 nitrate dependence, the British blockade, and Haber-Bosch: 1914–1918–Online, "Nitrate"; Wikipedia, "History of the Haber process"; standard histories crediting nitrogen fixation with sustaining Germany's war economy. 2 This issue, Technology ([p7](#)): CNBC, 17 Jul 2026; The Motley Fool, 14 Jul 2026 (Anthropic–Meta / Anthropic–Samsung / OpenAI–Broadcom).

There is a third way a narrow point can decide events, and it is the one the belligerents in the Gulf should study most carefully, because it is the trap of the party that thinks it holds the chokepoint. The Chinese commentary quoted on [p3](#) reached, unprompted, for the analogy — the United States in the Strait of Hormuz, a Global Times writer suggested, resembles Britain at Suez in 1956.¹ It is worth taking the comparison seriously rather than dismissing it as propaganda, because Suez is the definitive modern lesson in mistaking a chokepoint for power.

Britain in 1956 believed the Suez Canal was a thing it controlled, and that controlling it conferred strength. When Nasser nationalised the canal and Britain, France and Israel moved to take it back by force, the operation was a military success and a strategic catastrophe: American financial pressure — a run on the pound Washington declined to stop — forced a humiliating withdrawal within weeks, and the episode is generally marked as the moment the world learned Britain was no longer a power that could act alone.¹ The chokepoint Britain thought it held turned out to be holding *Britain*, exposing exactly how narrow its own real margin had become.

The party that assumes it holds the chokepoint may discover, at the worst moment, that the chokepoint has been holding it.

That is the warning under the whole Hormuz confrontation. Every party to it — Iran threatening the strait, Washington proposing tolls to “guard” it ([p4](#)), the Gulf states caught in the blast radius — is behaving as though the narrow point is an asset to be owned. Suez suggests it is more often a liability that owns you: the harder you grip a chokepoint, the more of your own strength you reveal to be riding on it, and the more you invite the discovery that your margin was always thinner than the map implied.

There is an asymmetry here worth making explicit, because it decides who wins these confrontations. The party that merely *threatens* a chokepoint and the party that *depends* on it are not playing the same

game. The threatener risks little — a mine, a drone, a declaration — and needs only to make passage uncertain, not to close it. The dependent party must keep the point open every single day, and is judged by its worst day, not its average one. That is why a comparatively weak actor can hold a strait against a far stronger one, and why the stronger party's instinct — to grip harder, to escalate, to prove control — is so often the move that exposes exactly how little slack it had. Britain discovered this in eleven days in 1956. The lesson has not aged.

Set the three episodes side by side and a rough decision tree emerges, the one every actor in this issue is somewhere inside. First: can you see your narrow point? Augustus could, and guarded it; the semiconductor industry could not, and lost a gas. Second: if the point sits in a rival's hands, can you build redundancy — your own Haber-Bosch — *before* it is used against you? Germany could; the AI labs are racing to, and may not finish in time. Third, and subtlest: are you the one who thinks he holds the chokepoint? Because that is Suez, and Suez is where confidence in a narrow point becomes the very thing that breaks you.

Thomas Reid, writing in 1786, gave the whole idea its cleanest form: “In every chain of reasoning, the evidence of the last conclusion can be no greater than that of the weakest link of the chain, whatever may be the strength of the rest.”² He was talking about arguments, not empires or supply chains, but the geometry is identical. What holds a thing up is never its average strength; it is its minimum. The rest of the chain can be magnificent and it will not matter.

Which leaves the genuinely hard part, the one Reid's tidy sentence quietly omits. You usually cannot tell in advance which link is weakest. The nail looks like every other nail right up until the shoe comes off. So the real discipline — for a war cabinet, a chip industry, a lab, or a government that just lost a minister to a single email — is not the heroic one of strengthening the whole chain, which is impossible, but the humbler, more boring one of going looking for the narrowest point on purpose, and paying it the attention it has done nothing yet to earn. This week, that narrow point was a strait, a gas cylinder, a desalination plant and an inbox. Next week it will be something else that has been working flawlessly, unremarked, for years — right up until it isn't.

SOURCES 1 On Suez 1956 as the marker of Britain's diminished reach: standard diplomatic histories of the Suez Crisis and the US-forced Anglo-French withdrawal; the Britain-at-Suez / US-at-Hormuz comparison as raised in Chinese commentary this week (see this issue, [p3](#)). 2 Thomas Reid, *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man* (1786), Essay VII.

Four times this week the news turned on a part too small to have been guarded — a strait, a gas cylinder, a desalination plant, an email. None of them was the biggest thing in its system. Each was the narrowest. That is usually where the story is: not at the strong point everyone defends, but at the quiet one nobody thought worth watching.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 48

The World: Al Jazeera, NBC News, NPR, CENTCOM, Maritime Executive, CNBC, Breitbart, Kyiv Post, Ukrinform, UN News, Bloomberg, Middle East Monitor, Fortune, Global Times.

Singapore / Property: PMO Newsroom, South China Morning Post, Mothership, Bloomberg, The Online Citizen, EdgeProp, MOH/MTI/SingStat, SMRT Newsroom, URA, The Edge Singapore, Stacked Homes, HardwareZone.

Technology: South China Morning Post, TrendForce, BigGo Finance, TechSpot, Micron, The Motley Fool, CNBC, Bloomberg, VideoCardz, Macworld, MarkTechPost, Interconnects.ai.

The Kit / Connected Home: 9to5Google, Android Authority, Engadget, The Korea Times, Sony/PR Newswire, Fortune, Financial Times, TechRadar, Matter Alpha, GitHub, HomeKitNews, MacRumors, Forbes.

Good Life / Screen & Sound: Gear Patrol, TechRadar, What Hi-Fi, Premier Guitar, Guitar World, Variety, WatchPro, dmarge, Boss Hunting, TTG Asia, TechTimes, MacRumors, Deadline, AppleInsider, HotNewHipHop, AlbumOfTheYear.

Family: South Dakota Searchlight, Insurance Journal, WLOX / Mississippi AG, AboutLawsuits.com, HarrisMartin, Common Sense Media, Axios, PBS

NewsHour, IBTimes.

Macro: TechTimes, CNBC, Bloomberg, TheStreet, CME FedWatch, Kalshi, TradingEconomics, StockAnalysis.com, PortfoliosLab, Kitco News, Fortune.

Curiosities: *Nature Communications*, NTU Singapore, The Straits Times, Scientific American, *Science*/AAAS, *Biophysics Reviews*, ScienceDaily, The Washington Post, Schmidt Ocean Institute, SciTechDaily.

Love & Life / Fitness: TechCrunch, Overtone, Dexerto, Inc., Northwestern Mutual / Harris Poll, *Nature Communications*, *GeroScience*, Mayo Clinic Press, NaturalNews.

Diary / Table: Singapore GP, Billboard, MICHELIN Guide Singapore, Zouk Group, Japan Travel, Tokyo Game Show, AFL.com.au, Rugby Australia, BIFF, theAsianparent, HungryGoWhere, Eatbook.sg.

Long Read: Benjamin Franklin, *Poor Richard's Almanack*; Britannica and standard histories of Roman Egypt and the *annona*; 1914–1918–Online and histories of the Haber–Bosch process; diplomatic histories of the 1956 Suez Crisis; Thomas Reid, *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man* (1786).